

FIRST CLIENT, NO PORTFOLIO

You don't need a portfolio.

You need proof of thinking.

The problem with portfolios

Prospects who haven't hired a copywriter before can't evaluate your samples.

They don't know if the copy converted.

They don't know what the brief was.

All they see is: words.

What they CAN evaluate

Whether you can think about their business.

That's the one thing they actually hire for.

Proof of thinking = 3 things

- Teardown of their current ad
- 1-page strategy doc for their offer
- Loom walking through your first 3 moves

Each takes under 90 minutes

Faster than building a portfolio.

Every one signals the trait prospects hire for.

The teardown template

1. Screenshot the ad
2. Mark 3 things you'd test changing
3. 1 sentence per change: what + why
4. Send it as your first message

Send 10. Expect 2–3 replies.

Of those, 1 turns into a paid conversation.

A 10% meeting rate. Most cold outreach closes at 1–2%.

Stop waiting for a portfolio.

Send the teardown this week.

Follow @csos for creative strategy breakdowns.